

THIRD EDITION

GLOBAL SOCIOLOGY COHEN & KENNEDY



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Global Sociology

Third Edition



Robin Cohen
& Paul Kennedy

With
Maud Perrier

Global Sociology

Third Edition



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For Selina and Sue



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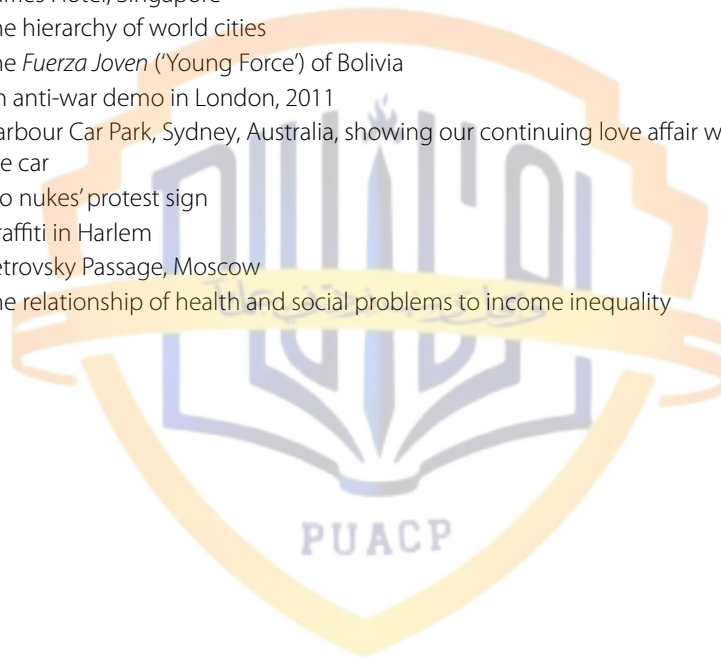
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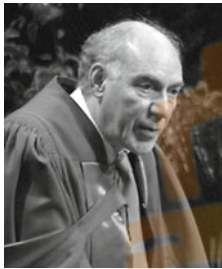
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His books include *Ghanaian Businessmen: From Artisan to Capitalist Entrepreneur in a Dependent Economy* (1980), *African Capitalism: The Struggle for Ascendancy* (1988), *Local Lives and Global Transformations: Towards World Society* (2010) and the edited volumes, *Globalization and National Identities* (2001) with Catherine Danks and *Communities Across Borders* (2002) with Victor Roudometof.

Recent research interests include work on green/ethical businesses, transnational professionals, especially architects, and social networks and life course changes among young educated continental Europeans working in Manchester.

Tour of the book

In this chapter we shall look first at some of the milestones in the discipline's development. T and universal claims, positioning the disciplin for a long time the primary concern was to co lar nations and their societies. To an extent this transnational outlook. Accordingly, we also ex tive changes that have prompted some so approaches that make sense of the more co around us – a global sociology. Although seer becoming more and more common, not all sc forth be the sole preoccupation of the professi further developing a global sociology is, indec insights into our evolving world.

KEY STARTING POINTS IN SOCIOLOGY

Sociology developed in nineteenth-century E of knowledge, notably philosophy, history a capture the import and drama of industrializ that were rapidly transforming the modern wo

◀ **Chapter introductions**
Short introductions to the key topics covered in each chapter help guide you through the textbook.

Figures and tables ▶
New and classic figures and tables summarize and elucidate the theory.

as war, poverty, financial crises or inequality. In address divided. Some centre their work on professional recogni while others work with policy-makers. Others again feel t and see that as a legitimate extension of their roles as socio although there are some overlaps between these categori them, we now, in effect, practise four kinds of sociology public (Table 1.1).

TABLE 1.1 Burawoy's four types of sociology

Type of sociology	Common cognitive practices	Target
Professional sociology	Advanced theoretical and empirical work, using explicit scientific norms	Peers,
Critical sociology	Foundational and normative, driven by moral vision	Critica debat
Policy sociology	Empirical, concrete, applied and pragmatic	Policy
Public sociology	More accessible/relevant theoretical and empirical work, lectures and media appearances	Design comm

Source: Adapted from Burawoy (2005).

A PAUSE TO REFLECT

Some sociologists suggest that, despite showing it is difficult to exclude the values and beliefs they engaged in research on the human condition, we be bias in sociological research? Can this be minor their values before they report their findings?

The search for sociological knowled public policy become all too evident. Soci destructive, produce unintended consequ their research often may challenge official gist off guard. In revealing findings that c ologists are expected to be even more met ples may make the argument clearer. Let nist views and most of the people you qu greatly on the attentions of enraptured i

◀ **A pause to reflect**
Questions throughout chapters encourage you to think critically about what you have just read.

Definitions ▶
Short definitions of key terms in sociology, or background information on particular important events help you get to grips with each chapter.

THE GREAT DEPRESSION (1929–39)

The most severe capitalist downturn ever known, although some have compared the global economic crisis beginning in 2007/8 with it. By late 1932, in the USA alone, around 15 million workers were unemployed. The crisis began in October 1929 when company share values on New York's Wall Street stock exchange crashed. A number of stockbrokers and investors jumped to their deaths from their skyscraper offices. A series of escalating bank and currency collapses soon turned the crisis into a global one. German Nazism and Japanese fascism were partly caused by the world economic collapse.

In the period up remained intelligent (they rarely lifted their them. In front of their Great Depression, the i ment of women on the social realities were fo or national contexts.

POST-1945: WIDE COMPLEX WORLD

The end of the Secor tional forces. Japan wa trializing and non-Wes had brought the USA the locus of political a

its part, the Soviet Union made enormous sending the first cosmonaut to space in 19 weaknesses in the economy. The French,

KEY CONCEPT

THE NEW INTERNATIONAL DIVISION OF LABOUR divides production into different skills and tasks spread across regions and countries rather than within a single company. From the 1970s onwards, as key production functions shifted away from the old industrial zones, hitherto agricultural countries, particularly in the Asia-Pacific region, rapidly joined the ranks of the new international division of labour.

THE NEW INTERNATIONAL DIVISION OF LABOUR

Partly in response to the a team of German resear that a **NEW INTERNATIONAL** were reacting particular and other newly indust deindustrialization of the observe in Chapters 4 growing tendency for locate the more labour-developing countries, so Advocates of the NII

ing processes in cheap labour havens did litt ment prospects in the poor countries in quest: the growing ranks of unemployed people in t TNCs. While these theorists suggest that the countries' ability to dominate the world capi 'global losers' in all countries. Like world syste ery being able to overcome its relative econo from dependence on raw material exports to t

◀ **Key concepts**
Concise discussions of key concepts in sociology or related disciplines such as anthropology, politics and economics are useful for revision.

Global thinkers ▶
Analyses of the important research undertaken by key thinkers in sociology and related disciplines provide some background to current sociological thinking.

GLOBAL THINKERS 1 IMMANUEL M. WALLERSTEIN (1930–)



Immanuel Wallerstein the most important ao since the 1970s. At the (1974: 15), Wallerstein in the late fifteenth into existence what economy ... it was social system the which is the distinct

What was hidden behind Wallerstein's apparently simple declaration was understandings of the world:

- For Wallerstein, political structures (like empires and states) were gi emphasis on interpenetrating trade networks that crossed state bo labour, market share and raw materials drove the world system forv emphasis on trade led many scholars to accuse Wallerstein of being someone who overemphasizes the causal role of economic factors. I social movements and politics, he has never entirely shaken off this

BOX 1.2 Post-1945 Western sociologists and the non-Western world

- **Barrington Moore** (1967, 1972) thought that a comparative historical approach could help us understand why some societies prospered while others languished, and why some became democracies and others dictatorships. In his ambitious comparative study, *Democracy and Dictatorship*, he considered how the cultural foundations, historical traditions and different kinds of peasantry and aristocratic systems of land tenure interacted in constraining and/or shaping the direction, speed and character of modernization in different societies.
- Other US sociologists like **Talcott Parsons** (1971) tended to talk in terms of 'modernization', which involved the 'non-Western' world 'catching up' with the 'Western' world and Japan.
- German scholar **André Gunder Frank** (1967, 1969), who worked in the USA, was influenced by the theories of 'dependency' and 'underdevelopment' (which he popularized their work by writing in English and extended it in new ways).
- Although the term 'Third World' originated with a French journalist, **Émile Durkheim** (1967) also drew from writings by Latin Americans, Asians and Africans to describe the characteristics of the Third World, one that was relatively poor, neither Western nor non-Western.

◀ **Boxed text**
Examples, case studies and timelines of key events help you to apply the theory to the real world.

Review ▶

Summaries of chapter content draw helpful conclusions and often look towards the future of the discipline.

pressure from their disgruntled, insecure citizens. They have devised policies to regulate destructive forces. The continuing power of the banks to resist far enough.

REVIEW

That sociology drew on Enlightenment thought and its strong positivist tradition. Sociology has developed with several important streams. One explores how subjective elements shape social life, dealing with human nature and social differences. Sociology therefore requires a balance of needs and has developed methodologies that require highly intimate data, but in ways that minimize intrusions. Nevertheless, stringent attempts to control the critiques of others do not preclude different political, social, economic and moral stances. In this book, we are particularly concerned with how the discipline can be used to develop a global social science.

FURTHER READING

- M. Davis's *Planet of Slums* (2006) provides an excellent overview of the experiences of different groups across the world.
- In *American Apartheid: Segregation and the Making of the Underclass*, Douglas M. Denton considers the consequences of deindustrialization for the urban poor.
- A. Sen's *Poverty and Famine: An Essay on Entitlement and Deprivation* (1982) is a classic work that is challenging and thought-provoking. (You can ignore some of the more technical arguments.)
- R. Wilkinson and K. Pickett's *The Spirit Level: Why Equality Matters* (2009) is a book that shows that greater equality benefits everyone, not just the rich. It is an exercise, not a political tract, but it has important implications for policy.

◀ **Further reading**
Annotated suggestions for further research, including books and journal articles, for those who want to learn more.

Questions and assignments ▶

Questions to test your understanding of chapter content, requiring you to conduct your own research and think independently.

K. L. Thachuk, contains detailed material on all the four chapters. L. Napoleon's *Terror Inc: Tracing the Money behind Global Terrorism* (2008) provides an accessible discussion of the fascinating links between terrorism and money, replete with numerous examples.

Many chapters in *States of Conflict: Gender, Violence and Resistance* (2008) provide vivid case studies, coupled with careful analysis of complex subjects.

QUESTIONS AND ASSIGNMENTS

1. How useful are official statistics to the sociological study of crime and so limitless a supply, is it possible to stop crime?
2. Show how patterns of social control have changed in the last century.
3. What are the new features of contemporary terrorism?
4. Using specific examples, examine how and why many families reflect the realities of gender oppression and violence.

Third edition

Robin Cohen and Paul Kennedy

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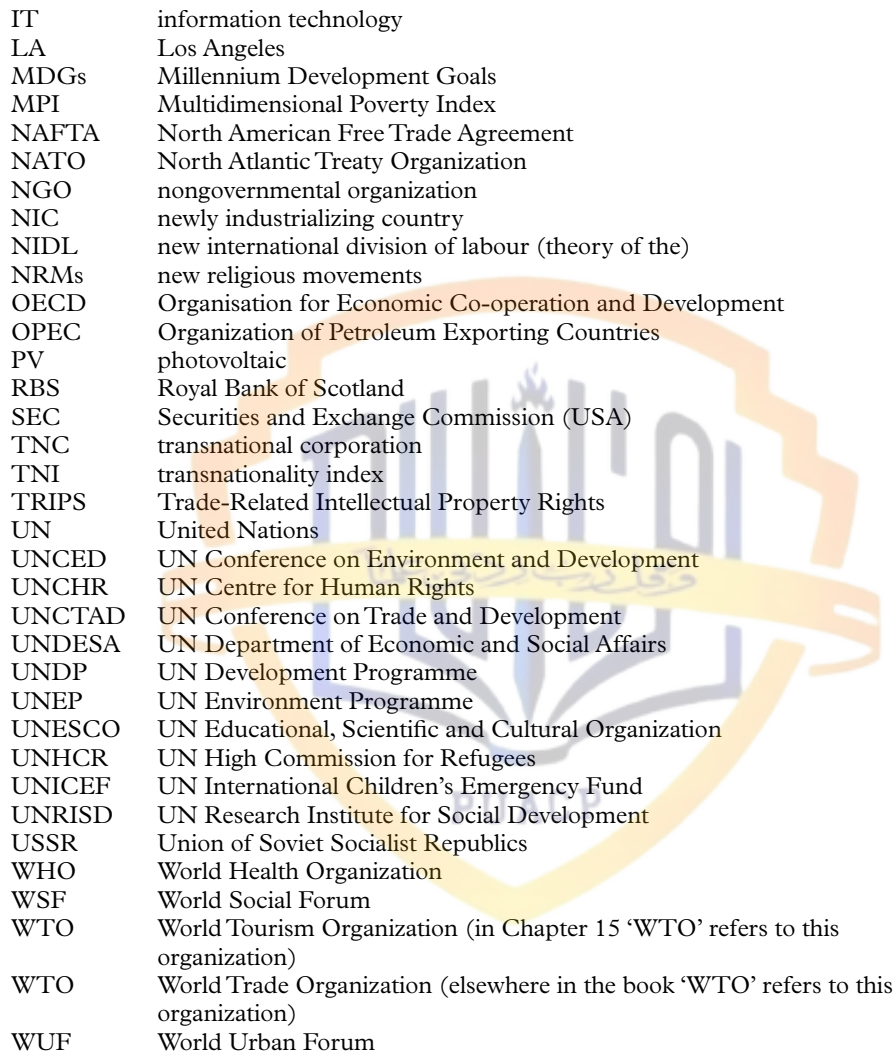
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Abbreviations and acronyms



9/11	11 September 2001 terrorist attack on twin towers in New York
AIDS	acquired immune deficiency syndrome
ASEAN	Association of Southeast Asian Nations
BIP	Border Industrialization Program
BRIC	Brazil, Russia, India and China (countries)
CCTV	closed-circuit television
CEDAW	Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination against Women
CIA	Central Intelligence Agency (USA)
CNN	Cable News Network
CO ₂	carbon dioxide
CPC	Communist Party of China
CSR	corporate social responsibility
DRC	Democratic Republic of the Congo
ECHR	European Court of Human Rights
EDL	English Defence League
EPZ	export-processing zone
ETI	Ethical Trading Initiative
EZLN	Zapatista National Liberation Army
EU	European Union
FDI	foreign direct investment
FTSE	Financial Times (and London) Stock Exchange (a stock index)
G7	group of seven (advanced industrial nations, now called the G8)
G20	group of twenty finance ministers and Central Bank governors
GATT	General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (now the World Trade Organization)
GDI	gross domestic income
GDP	gross domestic product
GM	genetically modified
GNP	gross national product
GSM	global social movement
HIPC	heavily indebted poor country
HIV	human immunodeficiency virus
ICC	International Criminal Court
ICT	information and communication technology
IDP	internally displaced person
IGO	international governmental organization
ILO	International Labour Organization
IMF	International Monetary Fund
IMR	infant mortality rate
INGO	international nongovernmental organization
IPCC	Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change
IQ	intelligence quotient



IT	information technology
LA	Los Angeles
MDGs	Millennium Development Goals
MPI	Multidimensional Poverty Index
NAFTA	North American Free Trade Agreement
NATO	North Atlantic Treaty Organization
NGO	nongovernmental organization
NIC	newly industrializing country
NIDL	new international division of labour (theory of the)
NRMs	new religious movements
OECD	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
OPEC	Organization of Petroleum Exporting Countries
PV	photovoltaic
RBS	Royal Bank of Scotland
SEC	Securities and Exchange Commission (USA)
TNC	transnational corporation
TNI	transnationality index
TRIPS	Trade-Related Intellectual Property Rights
UN	United Nations
UNCED	UN Conference on Environment and Development
UNCHR	UN Centre for Human Rights
UNCTAD	UN Conference on Trade and Development
UNDESA	UN Department of Economic and Social Affairs
UNDP	UN Development Programme
UNEP	UN Environment Programme
UNESCO	UN Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization
UNHCR	UN High Commission for Refugees
UNICEF	UN International Children's Emergency Fund
UNRISD	UN Research Institute for Social Development
USSR	Union of Soviet Socialist Republics
WHO	World Health Organization
WSF	World Social Forum
WTO	World Tourism Organization (in Chapter 15 'WTO' refers to this organization)
WTO	World Trade Organization (elsewhere in the book 'WTO' refers to this organization)
WUF	World Urban Forum

Introduction

Sociology involves the systematic study of the character of human interaction. Historical events, beliefs and social influences acting on an individual, family or wider social group often structure human behaviour. Their outcomes are experienced at a number of levels – local, national, regional and global. As we shall see later in this book, many sociologists are particularly adept at describing the patterns of social interactions at the community and national levels. Why do we argue that we now need a more macroscopic and comparative approach, a ‘global sociology’? This expression was first used by Wilbert E. Moore in the 1960s when he argued that the world had become ‘a singular system’ in three senses:

1. There was ‘a remarkable concurrence in the ideology of economic development’.
2. The ‘pool of options’ to achieve this was both limited in number and worldwide in scope.
3. ‘The life of the individual anywhere is affected by events and processes everywhere’ (Moore 1966: 481).

The processes that Moore observed have, however, accelerated and become more threatening. We now live within the orbit of the multiple, interlocking, sometimes dangerous and always challenging transformations, risks and crises that encompass our globe. Some are the product of earlier changes, such as imperialism or the spread of nation-state industrialization projects, while others are the result of recent forms of globalization. To understand these changes we require, in Albrow’s (1987) telling phrase, ‘a sociology for one world’.

RECENT GLOBAL CHANGES

In the body of the book, we examine these parallel transformations and sometimes crises taking place all around us in more detail, so here we provide only a brief outline of some important global changes arising over the past few years.

THE SHIFT IN ECONOMIC AND POLITICAL POWER

Although the USA remains the most powerful nation on earth militarily and economically, there has been a radical shift in power from the USA, Europe and Japan to other countries and regions. One would have to be living on Mars not to notice the extraordinary development of China. China is an unusual society in that the Communist Party enjoys the sole right to political organization, but competition in the economic sphere has been allowed to multiply, and sometimes run riot. This unusual combination of a political monopoly and a free market has lifted millions out of poverty, while China has been extending its influence to many parts of the world. India’s rise to prominence is more modest than China’s but, by contrast, it has mobilized its labour force, made significant advances in the information technology and service sectors, and become a large exporter of manufactured goods – all without foregoing its democratic traditions, which it inherited from the largely constitutional process

of decolonization. Competition between parties for a popular vote, a free press and respect for the rule of law remain important parts of India's achievement.

While the progress made by China and India is headline news, the global shift of power has by no means stopped there. Oil-rich countries have often been able to capitalize on the shortage of crude supplies resulting from political insecurity, for example in Nigeria and Iraq, or major accidents, for example the damage to the British Petroleum oil rig in the Gulf of Mexico. Often, they have used their funds, called 'sovereign funds', to buy large holdings in Western banks. By 2010, little Qatar had the world's highest gross domestic product per capita (a conventional measurement of wealth using the number of people in the country as the divisor), a calculation helped by the fact that there are fewer than 300,000 citizens in Qatar (Chapter 3). The Qatari government has also allied itself to the democratic forces in the region providing, for example, hundreds of millions of dollars in military aid to the rebels in Libya.

Other major beneficiaries in the shift of world power include Brazil, which has finally realized its founders' dream that it would one day be a great power. A succession of competent and effective administrators and political leaders has finally welded together its vast resources, engineering and scientific skills and large population. Russia's success is patchier and more prosaic: it has used its reserves of oil and gas to demand more from its hapless customers to the west (Chapter 4). Together, Brazil, Russia, India and China are now referred to as the 'BRIC' countries. This is a convenient acronym, which reminds us of the new geopolitical realities, but it should not conceal the fact that there have been significant advances elsewhere. South Africa has shrugged off the constraints of the apartheid system, although the country also benefited from the apartheid government's fiscal conservatism. Turkey's economy is booming. Its rates of urbanization and industrialization are now so dramatic that its prime minister, Recep Tayyip Erdogan, re-elected in 2011, has announced several multi-billion dollar development projects, including new towns and a canal to bypass the Bosphorus. Australia has made a successful transition from a mining and agricultural economy to one based on services, and appears to be one of the few developed countries to have emerged relatively unscathed from the recession beginning in 2007. Certain countries in tropical Africa, a region that seemed to be mired in poverty, are also showing significant growth spurts. Nigeria, for example, averaged an annual growth rate of 6% between 2004 and 2010, with little sign that the global recession has hindered its progress. Religious violence in the country may, however, damage its political stability, with ramifications for the economy and social structure.

GLOBAL WARMING AND CLIMATE CHANGE

The economic rise of China, India and a number of other countries has placed additional pressure on finite or shrinking world resources, especially water, fossil fuels, wood, minerals, agricultural land and food. Even without these hothouse economies, most environmental scientists agree that the warming of planet earth through human activities has increased greenhouse gas emissions, leading to climate change. Melting polar icecaps and glaciers, increasingly violent storms and more frequent droughts already provide grim indications of what may be in store. Equally worrying is the likelihood that climate change will aggravate or cause food shortages, environmental migration from low-lying or arid areas, and perhaps large-scale violence. It will also hit hardest those countries that are poor and least able to cope (Chapter 20). The remorseless pressure on the world's resources is likely to persist for at least the next four decades, with the continued growth of the world population – although the rate of increase has slowed – expected to peak at around 9.3 billion by mid-century (Chapter 12).

INCREASING INEQUALITY BOTH WITHIN AND BETWEEN SOCIETIES

For the past 30 years, technological change and more open markets have enabled transnational corporations (TNCs) and financial institutions to move or spread their operations

more easily across countries. This has allowed them some leeway in negotiating their tax contributions used in the reproduction of family, educational and infrastructural investment within the countries in which they operate. At the same time, workers are often coerced into accepting a decline in job security or risk plants being relocated elsewhere (Chapter 10). In stark comparison, all but the most highly skilled workers have far less opportunity, if any, to move freely across borders. They also tend to be relatively immobilized by local, cultural and family ties (Chapter 7). There is a growing disparity between economic growth in the leading developing countries and the vast majority left behind, sometimes called the 'Fourth World', where, according to some scholars (for example de Rivero 2001), the possibility of serious economic development is now an illusion.

Unregulated economic globalization constitutes only one reason for growing inequality, but it is certainly a major one. Here, decades of neoliberal, open market economic policies are partly responsible. The dangers of world inequality are many and include the possibility of growing social conflict expressed in the form of racism, Islamophobia and/or genocidal wars that spill outwards, growing crime and violence (much of it against women), and unmanaged migration flows. To these we can add the problems occasioned by the heightened dependence of individuals, families, businesses and governments on credit to supplement inadequate incomes (Chapters 4, 6 and 7).

THE TREND TOWARDS INDIVIDUALIZATION

Hand in hand with the pressures towards globalization is virtually an opposite trend, namely a primary concern with self-realization as one's main purpose in life (Beck and Beck-Gernsheim 2002). Individualization enhances the capacity for self-criticism and greater openness to the world – as we show in Chapters 2 and 15 when we discuss reflexivity. Yet, an obsession with self-realization could equally engender and legitimize a narcissistic, hedonistic, selfish 'me-culture' that overwhelms any sense of social/moral accountability towards one's community or nation, let alone to people in other countries. Even family life, so long a bulwark against wider pressures, has radically changed, simultaneously becoming a site of pleasure, togetherness and intimacy and one of exploitation, oppression and inequality (Chapter 13).

Some thinkers (Kenway et al. 2006; Szerszynski and Urry 2006) suggest that the mass media, the internet and the consumerist world of branded goods offer arenas for creative self-expression while enabling individuals to think of 'themselves as global' (Urry 2000: 185). Equally, however, far from helping to extend people's horizons beyond the local, mass consumer culture, the leisure industry and celebrity lifestyles might reinforce personal vanity and immersion in a private realm of fantasy constructed solely around personal hopes and obsessions. We evaluate these contrasting positions with respect to consumerism in Chapter 14.

THE WORLDWIDE RECESSION

Problems in one economic sector and a few countries – caused partly by the willingness of banks to lend too much unsecured credit to too many borrowers with poor prospects of servicing their debts – started in 2007 and rapidly spread and engulfed banks and financial institutions in many countries across the world. Ultimately, in October 2008, virtually the entire global financial system came close to collapsing, with dire consequences for businesses when they could no longer secure the credit they needed to keep their workers in jobs. Ordinary citizens struggled to access sufficient funds to purchase household goods, cars or properties. We discuss the financial crisis, and its causes and effects, in more detail in Chapter 4.

While optimists thought that the recession was nearly over in mid-2011, the collapse of stock market values in August 2011 showed that many hitherto strong links in the world economy were, in reality, remarkably fragile. In major economies such as the USA, the UK,

Japan and Italy, the recovery remained weak, investor and consumer confidence was low, and unemployment levels were persistently high. The US and European governments alike acted to stave off a depression by bailing out failing banks and injecting massive fiscal stimuli to sustain demand. However, the attempt to pay off the resultant deficits by cutting pensions and welfare payments, and reducing social services, has led to continuing fiscal crises, notably in Greece, Italy, Portugal and Spain, and to considerable social unrest – especially in Greece, Spain, Ireland, Italy, France and the UK. Greece is perhaps the most extreme example of the contradiction between the demand for austerity required by its creditors (the International Monetary Fund and the leading Eurozone countries) and the politics of the street, where many Greek protestors refuse to accept cuts to their benefits, wages, pensions, education and health services.

The emergence from the recession is gradual and uncertain elsewhere too. The German economy looks comparatively strong. Sobered by the long memories of the Great Depression and the two world wars, German people tend to be savers, not spenders. The level of personal debt was low when the crisis hit, and because the rental market remained buoyant, there was no housing ‘bubble’. By contrast, the Japanese economy has been flat for a long time and the effects of the tsunami and nuclear accident at Fukushima in 2011 have not helped. Modest growth is predicted for the intermediate future.

SOCIAL PROTEST AND THE AUDACITY OF HOPE

In the USA, the initial popularity of Barack Obama, sworn in as president in January 2009, largely contained radical politics. Many young people in the electorate, using the social media to reach their peers, embraced his optimistic message first articulated at his keynote address to the Democratic National Convention in 2004, when Obama asked his audience to embrace ‘the audacity of hope’:

Do we participate in a politics of cynicism or a politics of hope? ... It’s the hope of slaves sitting around a fire singing freedom songs; the hope of immigrants setting out for distant shores; the hope of a young naval lieutenant bravely patrolling the Mekong Delta; the hope of a millworker’s son who dares to defy the odds; the hope of a skinny kid with a funny name who believes that America has a place for him, too. Hope in the face of difficulty. Hope in the face of uncertainty. The audacity of hope! (Obama 2004)

The excitement of the occasion still shines through in the YouTube video (Obama 2004). He appeared to speak to and for a younger, culturally more heterogeneous group. Until the very last moment when US voters entered their voting booths, commentators were still unsure whether Obama’s part-black origins would prevent him from being elected, despite his attractions as a candidate and the negative feelings towards an unpopular incumbent Republican president. In the end, Obama triumphed to general acclaim, or perhaps profound relief that the Bush era was over. For the rest of the world, this new president seemed to connect in an important way. His mixed heritage meant that everyone could claim a slice of him. In Kenya, his father’s birthplace, the popular Senator Keg beer became known simply as ‘Obama’. His speeches, particularly a beautifully crafted address given in the Grand Hall of the University of Cairo in June 2009, appeared to signal the beginning of a new dialogue between the West and the rest. This is an extract from that speech:

There must be a sustained effort to listen to each other; to learn from each other; to respect one another; and to seek common ground. As the Holy Koran tells us: ‘Be conscious of God and speak always the truth.’ That is what I will try to do – to speak the truth as best I can, humbled by the task before us, and firm in my belief that the interests we share as human beings are far more powerful than the forces that drive us apart. ... Part of this conviction is rooted in my own experience. I am a Christian, but my father came from a Kenyan family that includes generations of Muslims. As a boy, I spent

several years in Indonesia and heard the call of the *azaan* [the Muslim call to prayer] at the break of dawn and the fall of dusk. As a young man, I worked in Chicago communities where many found dignity and peace in their Muslim faith.

Inevitably, the ‘audacity of hope’ in which Obama asked us to believe has given way to considerable disillusionment. Obama has certainly recognized the power of the emerging economies and has sought to adjust to a more complex and plural world; the mind map of international relations emerging from Washington is less hierarchical and more plural and networked. Power is to be shared and negotiated rather than exercised unilaterally. However, after several years in office, finding peace in the Middle East is as elusive as ever, the war in Afghanistan continues, and there are still prisoners held in Guantanamo Bay, despite the president’s promise to close the prison. Above all, Obama has had to show his electorate that he remains a strong president and a merciless enemy of al-Qaeda. In announcing the killing of Osama bin Laden on 2 May 2011, he vowed to continue the decade-long war against al-Qaeda and to defend the USA from any further terrorist attacks. In the US elections in November 2010, the Democratic Party suffered major losses at federal and state levels. Most commentators took this as a negative judgement of President Obama’s handling of the economic crisis.

In the USA and most countries of the developed world, social protest has predominantly stayed within the confines of conventional politics, although there have been quite dramatic, and occasionally violent, street protests arising from movements protesting against financial greed, corrupt politicians and welfare cuts, particularly in Spain, Greece and Italy. This anger is also reflected in the Occupy Wall Street movement (Figure 0.1), supported by many of

the young people who had put such trust in Obama’s candidacy. One survey indicated that 64% of the protesters were less than 34 years of age (Captain 2011). By October 2011 protests had spread, with the help of Facebook and mailing lists, to 82 countries and 950 cities. Other social protests have included marches of tens of thousands of people against what was seen as a rigged election in Russia. However, anger at the state of the world is not only the preserve of the left. The far right has made significant gains in European elections in traditionally social democratic countries like Sweden, Denmark, the Netherlands and Belgium, where xenophobic passions have been inflamed. New migrants and established ethnic minorities provide convenient targets for those in the longstanding populations experiencing social dislocation, unemployment and uncertainty.



FIGURE 0.1 The Occupy Wall Street movement

This movement has galvanized opposition to corporate greed and the bailouts of the banks. Many younger people are involved, while a significant number are students frustrated at their job prospects.

THE ARAB SPRING

Somewhat unexpectedly, the audacity of hope can be recast as the leitmotiv of the events in the Middle East and North Africa commencing in December 2010 and subsequently dubbed ‘the Arab Spring’. Starting purportedly (the story has been disputed) in Tunisia, where a vegetable seller resisted a local bureaucrat’s orders, strikes, demonstrations and uprisings took place in Tunisia and Egypt (where the protesters achieved a measure of success), and in

Bahrain, Yemen, Iraq, Jordan, Morocco and Algeria. Minor protests have taken place elsewhere in the region. By mid-2011, there was a massive trial of strength between the government and the protestors in Syria, and a violent contest for power in Libya, which culminated in the brutal death of President Gaddafi in October.

The Arab Spring is of crucial significance for at least four reasons:

1. It signifies the power of the ideas of freedom, democracy and constitutional government in a region marked by decades of repressive, authoritarian government.
2. It demonstrates the power to mobilize people through the internet and social networking sites, such as Facebook, Twitter and YouTube.
3. It captures the anger of disillusioned young, educated people whose career ambitions have been thwarted and who remain a potent reminder that inequality and lack of opportunity can destabilize an existing political order.
4. There are some long-term implications for the balance of power between Israel and its neighbours and between the Middle East and Western countries more generally.

While we are in the midst of the uprisings it is difficult to predict their ultimate significance, but it is perhaps useful to reproduce the notably cautious note struck by Benantar (2011: 7):

The Arab democratic uprisings are facing two major challenges. *The first* one is a genuine transformation: the revolts have to effect a real change of regimes, not just a change within current regimes. The democratic process is hard and long and the democratic learning curve a steep one. The Arab people have taken the first step, but the counter-democratic forces are still in power in many states including Tunisia and Egypt. *The second* one is the role of the major external actors which try to influence the Arab democratic process in order to preserve a kind of right of control over the emerging democracies. Many external powers prefer a limited democracy in the Arab world: sufficient to overthrow authoritarianism and to calm popular fervor but limited to the extent of being truly independent from foreign influence.

The Arab Spring has since spawned a wave of supposedly copycat protests in other parts of the world, but the resemblances are often imperfect. 'The Chilean winter' comprised the mobilization of students, angry at educational reforms, but also at the authoritarian style of the Chilean government. In Israel, 250,000 people took to the streets demanding a reduction in housing costs and in frustration at the neoliberal policies of the country. Interestingly, at least some elements of the protest movement want the Israeli government to open a more fruitful dialogue with its Arab neighbours. In the UK, demonstrations against the harsh policing of the black community turned into a destructive spree, accompanied by looting of popular consumer goods. In all these events, mobile phones (in particular) were used to direct and energize the protesters.

SOCIOLOGY'S CONTRIBUTION TO UNDERSTANDING GLOBAL ISSUES

In trying to explore the interactions, transactions and processes that arise at a global level, sociologists sometimes employ insights from other social sciences – notably economics, political science, anthropology and history. Certain theories and methods, however, are intrinsic to the discipline and many teachers insist that their students understand the evolution of the ideas of the pioneers of sociology. While there is a lot to be said for interdisciplinary and multidisciplinary perspectives, we think it is important first to gain some command of the fundamental theories, methods, findings and sensibilities of your chosen discipline. Before indicating the distinctive contribution of sociology, however, we will make a few remarks here about political science, economics and political economy.

Political scientists examine the policies and decisions that governments and political elites make in response to electoral outcomes and the lobbies of various interest groups; the main focus is on the national level. International relations – the branch of political studies that focuses on the global sphere – is primarily concerned with relations between competing nation-states in an inherently anarchic world. In both cases, the emphasis tends to be on large organizations and institutions – governments, parliaments, ministries, or intergovernmental organizations such as the United Nations (UN) or World Bank. How do the elites who manage and control these bodies win power, reach international agreements, formulate policies and make decisions? Scholarly work in this area has cast light on global political life, especially on new global attempts to solve world problems through intergovernmental laws and agreements. This focus on the macro level, however, gives us little understanding of how ordinary people and social groups can, could or actually do help shape global processes. This is a serious limitation for our purposes.

Economics is primarily concerned with the rational decisions that entrepreneurs make to maximize their profits and consumers make to satisfy their needs or wants. A market economy governed by competition and a price mechanism supposedly guarantees two benefits – maximization of social welfare for the majority and efficient deployment of scarce resources in the overall economy (Keen 2001: 39). Moreover, it permits individuals to seek their private and selfish goals. To understand how this supposedly works in practice, economists adopt assumptions about how individuals make rational choices. They then deploy theoretical arguments and models – some requiring highly complex mathematical formulations – to aggregate these assumptions so they can understand how an entire economy reaches equilibrium in the supply and demand for goods.

While economics has delivered some impressive results, particularly using multivariate and regression analyses, the discipline has also attracted fierce criticism, particularly in the wake of the recession commencing in 2007. At heart, the models and assumptions that most economists use depend on implausible, abstract individuals. It is difficult to take seriously the idea that individuals invariably make rational, informed decisions based solely on price, opportunity and market signals. Actual consumers often fall into debt through pursuing lifestyles shaped by powerful advertising. Similarly, speculative bubbles frequently occur when investors irrationally buy into or escape from markets in currencies, commodities, government bonds or equities. As Keen (2001: 239) suggested, instead of looking ‘dispassionately at investment prospects and world economic conditions’, investors are likely to ‘look furtively and emotionally at each other’ – displaying a kind of herd instinct – as they try to predict, then follow, how other investors will evaluate government policies, the strength of different companies and the lure of new opportunities. Unusually for a discipline whose practitioners have normally expressed considerable self-confidence in their theory and methods, some key economists are now seeking to reform their profession. A good example is the Institute for New Economic Thinking (INET), founded at King’s College London in October 2009, with the financial help of George Soros, the well-known investor with a penchant for new ideas. According to its opening credo, the institute

recognizes problems and inadequacies within our current economic system and the modes of thought used to comprehend recent and past catastrophic developments in the world economy. The institute embraces the professional responsibility to think beyond these inadequate methods and models and will support the emergence of new paradigms in the understanding of economic processes. (INET 2010)

Because it focuses on the power relations behind international trade regimes, national and global patterns of inequality, and the successes or failures of national economic development programmes, the subdiscipline of political economy is more useful for understanding global changes. We align ourselves with a number of key propositions in political economy and several of our earlier chapters reflect this perspective. Through sociology, however, one

can go further. In particular, the discipline facilitates the examination of areas of human endeavour about which neither conventional economics nor political science can tell us much. This is partly because the scope of sociological research is not confined to one dimension of human experience, but encourages one to explore how these spheres interact with each other and with people's cultural and social activities. In addition, sociologists are interested in the everyday, personal micro relations, affiliations and social interactions of real – not abstract – social actors. Naturally, we are aware that these social relations are embedded in vast macro structures and institutions controlled by various political, financial and cultural elites and driven by impersonal forces such as market pressures. We are especially interested in how individuals perceive, react to or cope with incoming global forces or even how they learn to surf the vast waves of global life and mesh them in some small way into their private micro worlds.

Sociologists are vitally interested in investigating how the interpersonal, micro relations that social actors deploy help to shape global processes, whether they operate as individuals, in friendship groups, as small businesses, social networks or as families. Global social actors include migrants, tourists, consumers, professionals, students, criminal gangs, users of the internet and social networking forums, and cross-national marriage partners. In these and other ways sociology fills the gaps, opens to scrutiny and makes sense of those rather large empty spaces of missing knowledge that other social science disciplines mostly neglect. In the pages that follow we shall endeavour to show how you can better understand your world, at the personal, social and, especially, global levels.

THE ORGANIZATION OF THIS BOOK

This book is divided into four parts, with the following broad themes:

1. the *interpretations* that have been used to explain our increasingly globalizing world (Chapters 1–5)
2. the *divisions and inequalities* induced by global changes (Chapters 6–11)
3. the *experiences* of individuals, social groups, families and urban residents (Chapters 12–18)
4. the *dynamics and challenges* facing an emerging global society (Chapters 19–22).

INTERPRETATIONS

In Chapter 1, we discuss how sociology as a discipline evolved, what it explains and some of its limitations. We show that some of the building blocks of the discipline, such as the notion of 'community', worked well at a local level; while others, such as 'society', were more or less synonymous with the nation-state. As social, cultural, economic and political changes began to assume a global character, late twentieth-century sociologists had to adapt some of their ideas and perspectives to a global scale. In Chapter 2, we draw you into our understanding of two key concepts, 'globalization' and 'globality', necessary direction finders for our long intellectual journey. The first concept has now spread into common usage and is often found in magazines and newspapers. It refers to the ways in which the world is being knitted together by the increased volume and speed of cross-border transactions. Globalization, particularly of social and cultural activities, leads to the elaboration of a second and less well-rehearsed concept, the idea of globality. Whereas globalization refers to the objective, external ties that bind us together, globality alludes to the subjective, personal awareness that many of us share and are increasingly likely to share – a common fate.

A major theme of this book (and an abiding concern of sociology) is how social change arises and becomes diffused. Despite the ubiquity of contemporary means of transport, globalization and globality have not been dropped from the sky by passing aircraft. They are the outcomes of a long evolutionary process whereby small isolated societies and large civili-

zations came to relate to one another. In Chapter 3, we situate the moments when humankind became increasingly capable of understanding itself collectively. Contacts arose from long-distance trade, from the spread of world religions such as Islam, Buddhism and Christianity, and from the force of colonialism and imperialism. The idea of a universal humanity was developed particularly by European Enlightenment thinkers who, although they recognized that there were 'backward regions', thought all were capable of reaching the end state of modernity.

In Chapter 4, we depict substantive changes in the world of work. Rapid and unprecedented technological change and intensifying international competition have led to economic insecurity and the internationalization of work. The more vulnerable position of women has led to the feminization of work. The development of flexible labour markets has also led to the casualization of work. For the winners, particularly those with portable skills in growing sectors like the information-related industries, these changes herald 'new times' – offering opportunities for greater individual freedom and self-realization and a more democratic, decentralized, less hierarchical workplace and society. The losers see only 'hard times' – dominated by fragmenting businesses, labour redundancies and part-time and poorly paid jobs. The crisis induced by the 'financialization' of the global economy since the 1980s is also considered.

The nation-state is a relatively recent political organization, dating in its complete form from the French Revolution. Nation-states replaced multinational kingdoms, principalities, religious domains and empires. In Chapter 5, we consider whether globalization inevitably means that there will be a decline in the power and influence of the nation-state. We look at the changing role of the state, in particular at the transition from the Bush to the Obama presidencies and what this implies for future state relations.

DIVISIONS AND INEQUALITIES

Global changes are overlaid on prior inequalities between people and serve also to introduce new lines of dominance and subordination. Sociologists have always given much thought to the problem of how to conceptualize and explain the forms of inequality found in all societies and the ways in which these vary both between societies and over time. The unequal distribution of power, wealth, income and social status between individuals and groups is not random but is patterned or structured. Some groups are marginalized; others enter the charmed circle of privilege and security. In Chapters 6 and 7, we provide an account for the extremes of poverty and wealth, power and powerlessness in today's world. According to some theorists, whose views are examined in Chapter 8, the system is rigged to protect the interests of the leading players. Can those who lose out ever alter their place in the pecking order? Could it be to the ultimate benefit of the powerful that the poor achieve some upward social mobility and raise their standards of living? Can social uplift be induced from the top, for example through the actions of benign social democratic politicians? Alternatively, will the only redress come from oppositional social and political movements emanating from the grassroots level?

Those who die from famine, natural disasters or in civil wars are the ultimate global losers, but other groups are also highly vulnerable. As the race gets faster, those at the back – groups such as the unskilled, the unemployed, those who experience discrimination and the urban poor – appear to be trailing even further behind. We probe the condition and possible trajectories of some of the victims of recent global changes, probing the ways sociologists have grappled with various schemes to understand how these forms of inequality and disadvantage arise and how global change perpetuates, modifies or enhances them. In Chapter 7, we concentrate on class, noting the development of an unprotected working class, dubbed a 'precariat'. In Chapter 8, we consider forms of hierarchy based on gender and the various ways in which women's networks have moved to a global scale of activity. Next, in Chapter 9, we examine the origins and manifestations of race and racism from a biological, historical

and sociological perspective. The interaction of inequalities based on class, gender and race is discussed using the idea of 'intersectionality'.

Chapter 10, the final chapter in Part 2, centres on corporate power. We show how TNCs have become dominant players in global affairs. They profit from the increased level of economic globalization and indeed can be said partially to cause this outcome. Are these ubiquitous organizations the Trojan horses, or perhaps the battering rams, of international capital? Such is their power and influence that they are often accused of dictating to rich and powerful states, while completely overwhelming poor states. What is their economic role in integrating the global economy? What are the social consequences, positive and negative, of TNCs' activities?

EXPERIENCES

As we have explained, one of the great strengths of sociology is its focus on the behaviour of people, whose lives are increasingly meshed in global flows. For example, the flows of tourists, international communications, new forms of transnational urban, cultural and sporting life, and the more intense globalization of many religions create unsettling experiences for people in all nation-states and across national frontiers. Part 3 analyses these experiences. In Chapter 11, we look at how global crime and particularly the drugs trade impact on the lives on consumers and producers. Those who principally profit from the trade are the 'drug barons', the smugglers and the dealers. But it is difficult to eliminate the trade while it forms so vital a part of the cash income gained by poor farmers in countries like Afghanistan, Nepal and Jamaica and while the demand for recreational and addictive drugs in rich countries seems insatiable. Also in Chapter 9, we provide a wider context in which to understand the origins and character of terror and terrorism and how violence has affected the welfare of many women.

To both popular opinion and concerned policy-makers, population growth is one of the most critical problems facing the world. Under intense pressure, politicians have sanctioned or encouraged extreme measures to control population. But, as we argue in Chapter 12, we need to distinguish evidence about population growth from prediction, projection and prejudice, and we need to question whether measures to control migration and population growth are appropriate and effective. Only a small proportion of the world's population consists of international migrants, but numbers alone are not the major driving force to control and restrict global migration. International migrants can bring highly motivated labour, economic skills and cultural renewal to many countries. They fill gaps in the labour market, particularly in affluent Western countries where the population is ageing and fertility is low. Nonetheless, they have managed to inflame public sentiments in many countries and politicians have consequently sought to control and restrict their movement.

In Chapter 13, we adopt a global approach to the study of family and intimacy and ask what happens to family relationships under conditions of globalization. Looking particularly at the UK and Japan, we examine how family structures and everyday family life differ across the globe. What are the rituals of intimacy? How do we negotiate our rights and responsibilities towards our families? We start by examining early sociological analyses of the family and consider the contribution that feminist scholars have made to family sociology. We then assess whether individualization theories are an accurate characterization of what has been happening to family relationships lately.

Drink a cup of coffee or tea and you instantly connect to the global marketplace. The list of world goods that arrives in this way is formidable and grows all the time. World goods are products that in whole or part are grown, processed, packed, manufactured, recorded, filmed or staged in a multiplicity of locations often far from the place where we finally purchase and experience them. In Chapter 14, we look at the effect of multiple sourcing. In particular, we ask whether we have become easy targets to those who wish to sell us consumer goods or whether consumers have been empowered by the choice available in the global marketplace.

We are increasingly aware that our purchases and possessions also carry various meanings, from the discreet logos of an exclusive brand to the ‘in your face’ messages that many consumers emblazon on their T-shirts.

In Chapter 15, we show how forms of identity based on lifestyle and leisure have replaced or augmented earlier bonds of loyalty and association based on family, community, nation and work. With increased affluence and the fragmentation of class loyalties, many people in affluent and poorer countries alike are constructing a life narrative around their participation in leisure activities like sport and tourism. We discuss both these activities. The rise of mass international tourism necessarily involves the mobility of people who have an opportunity to engage in direct social exchanges with hosts and who experience other societies at first hand. This creates at least the possibility of shared cross-cultural experiences.

Girding the globe are lines of communication that snake along the seabed, stretch across the terrain and bounce from satellites to earth. As we look at the ubiquitous television screens, our sense of distance from other places and other societies suddenly shrinks into insignificance. We live, in a famous phrase, in a ‘global village’. As is made clear in Chapter 16, who controls the media and channels of communications and for what purposes provide important sociological data. We also discuss the significance of the telephone, particularly the mobile phone, along with the arrival of linked computer networks, as a mass consumer good. These have rocketed information – its processing, storage, creation and distribution – to a central place in the national and global economy. We also consider the newly important role of the social media.

For sociologists, the key issue is not whether religion is ‘true’ or ‘false’, but why it manifests itself in all societies, what meanings are invested in it, and what social functions it provides. Other pertinent questions raised in Chapter 17 include whether there is a long-term tendency towards secularization (the normal finding that is still accepted by many sociologists), or whether we are experiencing a significant and long-term revival of religious sentiment. We review what sociologists have contributed to the study of religion, consider why religion has claimed so powerful a place in contemporary life, examine how the global claims of religion are advanced, and ask whether the practice of religion provides a threat to social cohesion or is a means of attaining that condition.

For much of human history, life was rural. In the year 1800, 97% of the world’s population lived in rural areas. Fast forward to the year 2000 and we find that 254 cities each contained over 1 million people. The forms of settlement and the ways people lived in cities became the sites of study by some of the world’s most eminent sociologists. Durkheim described the transition from ‘mechanical’ to ‘organic’ forms of solidarity; Simmel saw large cities as inducing anonymity, loneliness and the sense of being a stranger, while Park and Burgess at the University of Chicago looked at the ‘ecological patterning’ and spatial distribution of urban groups. As we explain in Chapter 18, in the current era, certain cities, called ‘global cities’, are emerging, with residents sharing conditions of life, attitudes, behaviour patterns and tastes with equivalent residents of other global cities rather more than with their co-citizens living in the hinterlands. They might lose their national culture or downgrade it in favour of an international and cosmopolitan culture.

DYNAMICS AND CHALLENGES

All too often, the literature of globalization assumes that people are mere chaff in the wind, unable to influence the nature and direction of social change. In Part 4, we question this assumption and show how global social movements have emerged or been re-energized. These movements connect struggles at different levels, attempt to reshape the emerging world order and seek to create democratic and participatory possibilities. In Chapter 19, we show how the public sphere is gradually widening as an informed citizenry uses access to information and the growing possibility for mobilization to develop organizations that are both free from state interference and able to challenge its authority. Having such a civil

society is properly regarded as a sign that people are, at least potentially, capable of taking on state power and globalization, both often depicted as inanimate forces, playing out their logic without human intervention. When social organizations are involved in creating links and networks to advance their particular causes they are called 'social movements', and when they operate transnationally, 'global social movements'.

One of the most influential and visible global social movements is the environmental or green movement, discussed in Chapter 20. The development of an environmental movement is a major reversal of the prevailing nineteenth-century idea of unquestioned progress and civilization. The increased consciousness of the threat of global warming has finally mobilized the leaders of some powerful nation-states into effecting international agreements to control carbon dioxide emissions and making largely rhetorical commitments to protect the environment. However, the power of the energy lobby in the USA and the massive use of non-sustainable energy by China in its breakneck thrust to industrialization are both important constraints in developing a viable global environmental strategy to protect our vulnerable world.

The creation of strong social bonds is one of the most powerful of human impulses and, as we have seen, is an abiding concern for sociologists. Paradoxically, for some the threat of globalization often reinforces family and kinship and other local attachments, ethnic sentiments and religious beliefs. Many people seem to need to belong to closely knit groups that protect their sense of self and provide a feeling of wellbeing and security. As we explain in Chapter 21, this tendency is usefully understood as 'identity formation', a process that happens at a number of levels. Often identity formation can be benign, for example in looking after the welfare of one's family, including infants or vulnerable seniors. However, the subnational level where ethnic groups, sharing a common descent, religion or language, are mobilized often generates enormous tensions. The global age has thus produced an unexpected and even perverse outcome. Despite, or perhaps because of, the pressures to come together, fierce struggles have ensued to keep people apart. Although we lay emphasis on 'localism' – to encompass movements based on religion, race, ethnicity and subnational sentiments – we also reflect the possibility of people creating ties between themselves that foretold the development of transnational and cosmopolitan consciousness.

In Chapter 22, we conclude by considering the continuing controversies and emerging debates in global sociology. One debate revolves around the extent of globalization and the differing reactions to it. We use some convincing empirical research to show that globalization is indeed a powerful and growing force in the contemporary world. There are those who support, decry or wish to reform aspects of globalization. While the reformers have made some progress in the attempts to change the global order, there has been little headway made at the level of constructing an ideological alternative to neoliberalism, which has occasioned such a massive shock to the functioning of the world economy and society. The collapse of cherished ideologies (like communism) and the near collapse of the certainties of neoliberalism have allowed some space for alternative, even utopian, thinking. Hopefully, this will give us some new conceptions and new ways forward. In particular, we argue that global public policy needs to develop in five areas – reviving mutuality, managing difference, creating greater equality, promoting a more pervasive democracy, and developing a sustainable economic and environmental model.

PART 1

Interpretations



1

The making of global sociology

In this chapter we shall look first at some of the key starting points for sociologists and some milestones in the discipline's development. The founders of the discipline made ambitious and universal claims, positioning the discipline as a general science of humankind. However, for a long time the primary concern was to construct sociologies that made sense of particular nations and their societies. To an extent this inhibited or delayed the move towards a more transnational outlook. Accordingly, we also examine the more recent theoretical and substantive changes that have prompted some sociologists to develop concepts, theories and approaches that make sense of the more complex and interconnected world we now see around us – a global sociology. Although seeing the discipline through a global perspective is becoming more and more common, not all sociologists would agree that this should henceforth be the sole preoccupation of the profession. Nonetheless, we hope to convince you that further developing a global sociology is, indeed, a vital and necessary goal that gives crucial insights into our evolving world.

KEY STARTING POINTS IN SOCIOLOGY

Sociology developed in nineteenth-century Europe by positioning itself against prior bodies of knowledge, notably philosophy, history and theology. All three were seen as unable to capture the import and drama of industrialization, urbanization and revolution, processes that were rapidly transforming the modern world.

SOCIOLOGY AS SCIENCE

Like economists and political scientists, sociologists aligned themselves to an emerging body of secular scientific thought known as the Enlightenment (see Chapter 3). Auguste Comte (1798–1857), who coined the term 'sociology', argued that the gradual understanding of scientific laws would make sociology the governing science that glued all other forms of science together. For this to happen, observation, experiment, comparison and history would be utilized to enhance the scientific claims of the discipline (Kreis 2000).

Comte's influence eventually gave rise to an approach called 'positivism'. This can briefly

be defined as the attempt to discover, measure and analyse regularities and patterns in social behaviour in an attempt to minimize the influence of the sociologist's own (value-laden) interpretations. Of course, unlike the natural sciences, sociologists cannot ethically conduct controlled experiments on people in the same way that laboratory scientists can manipulate or dissect living, non-human creatures to conduct and test their research, although the latter are also subject to growing ethical scrutiny and regulation. Nonetheless, using large data sets, for example from censuses and aggregate data on income and expenditure, through complicated statistical calculations (such as multivariate analyses), and by comparisons across space and time, sociologists have been able to offset, although not completely obviate, some of their initial scientific disadvantages.

SOCIOLOGY AS THE COMPARATIVE STUDY OF SOCIAL LIFE AND SOCIETY

Perhaps the most obvious and crucial characteristic of humankind is that practically everybody lives collectively in what is generally termed 'society'. Hermits throughout history constitute an interesting exception, although even they often re-enter social life after undergoing a period of spiritual renewal (France 1996: Ch. 1). In any case, we need to make the obvious point that if we all dispersed to live by ourselves, humankind would disappear.

Thus, we are social creatures, so share certain attributes and behave in certain common ways that do not rely on our individual beliefs, nationalities, ages, gender, statuses or wealth, important as these and other factors are in describing how we differ. At the same time, we do not have to experience biological modification (understood in the Darwinian sense of evolution) to adjust to large-scale changes, for example in the move from preindustrial to industrial society, or in the phenomenon that interests us, the move towards a more global society. We can record our actions, recall our history, reflect backwards and project forwards. We can stick to old ways or adopt new ideas. This makes the tasks of sociologists different from and more complicated than those of biologists, who can assume that inherited characteristics largely control animal behaviour (Elias 1978: 108). To investigate our more complex subject matter, we therefore have to look at how particular societies have evolved, compare them with others, and consider which social changes and behavioural patterns seem to be universal or, by contrast, which seem to be particular to one society or cluster of societies.

SOCIOLOGY AS IMAGINATIVE UNDERSTANDING

Any consideration of variations in social conduct between societies raises the question of whether scientific sociologists can really understand all the fine grains of human behaviour and social interaction through formal methods and statistical techniques. We must recognize that positivist sociologists have achieved much in accumulating reliable information, developing testable concepts (called 'hypotheses'), refining research techniques to ensure greater reliability, and producing a body of social policy. In the case of the latter, their work has informed governments on everything from the causes of crime and football hooliganism to social mobility (how people move up and down the class and occupational structure) and the value of educational attainment. Nevertheless, other approaches have emerged and flourish alongside positivism, complementing its insights.

Especially important here is the interest in the 'the self' or the 'subjective' in social life, a crucial dimension that is largely missing in statistically led sociology. This takes us into the meaning of a particular act – the meaning, that is, to the social actor, to other social actors or to an outside observer, who may or may not be a sociologist. To address this issue, the great German sociologist Max Weber (in Coser and Rosenberg 1976: 213–14, 219) called for *Verstehen* – loosely translated as 'understanding', but in one sense better thought of as 'insight' or even 'empathy'. *Aktuelles Verstehen* is a form of superficial, immediate understanding, while

erklärendes Verstehen probes motivations, intentions and context to give a deeper meaning or possible interpretation.

Subjective or interpretative sociology gained its most powerful expression in what is known as ‘symbolic interactionism’, a label applied to a group of sociologists working in Chicago who followed Weber’s emphasis on *Verstehen*. As Rock (1996a: 859) explains, symbolic interactionists argue that knowledge is not a simple mirror of an object. Rather, ‘people actively create, shape and select their response to what is around them. Knowledge is then presented as an active process in which people, their understanding and [external] phenomena are bound together.’ Sociologists working in this tradition seek to get inside people’s skins, as it were, to see how social actors (as well as others around them) understand situations symbolically and literally. This is particularly important when the subjects are not respectable or conventional citizens and are the objects of all manner of prejudices and stereotypes. Sociologists working in this tradition often explore the social worlds of criminals, prostitutes, drug users, HIV sufferers, sexual deviants and gang members.

SOCIOLOGY AND THE SEARCH FOR KNOWLEDGE

Honesty and integrity are at the heart of any genuine search for knowledge. This means that sociologists, like other scientists (*scientia* is the Latin word for ‘knowledge’, so there is no reason to be diffident about using the expression), cannot start by assuming the answer. We have to let the facts speak for themselves, honestly report the answers our respondents give, faithfully record our observations and not twist arguments to suit our private purposes or political positions. For positivist sociologists this is so self-evident it is barely worth mentioning. Those working on comparative and historical sociology and those in the interpretative tradition also seek to follow scientific procedures and methodologies.

A PAUSE TO REFLECT

Some sociologists suggest that, despite showing honesty and integrity in conducting their research, it is difficult to exclude the values and beliefs they hold. Precisely because we are human and engaged in research on the human condition, we may find ourselves ‘taking sides’. Is there bound to be bias in sociological research? Can this be minimized by insisting that sociologists openly declare their values before they report their findings?

The search for sociological knowledge may, however, mean that the inadequacies of public policy become all too evident. Sociologists often uncover policies that are ineffective, destructive, produce unintended consequences, or are ethically indefensible. The subjects of their research often may challenge official characterizations, but may also throw the sociologist off guard. In revealing findings that contradict their own assumptions and beliefs, sociologists are expected to be even more meticulous in their research reports. Taking two examples may make the argument clearer. Let us suppose you are a researcher with strong feminist views and most of the people you question say they love to look glamorous and depend greatly on the attentions of enraptured males to make them feel good about themselves. Suppose again you are a sociologist with Marxist views and your working-class respondents say that they have no sympathy with their fellow workers. In fact, many cannot wait to make enough money to send their children to posh schools so they can escape their class background. You may not like these answers, but you have faithfully to report them. Nor should you at any point prompt or suggest an answer. To do so may mean receiving the answer you want to hear (many people will effect a friendly consensus with interviewers or perhaps just want to get rid of them), but you would thereby be engaged in an ideological, not a socio-

logical, exercise. Because we are human and dealing with human behaviour (not something like carbon dioxide emissions, atomic matter or molecules), it is even more important that we do not cheat.

SOCIOLOGY AS CRITIQUE AND ITS PUBLIC RESPONSIBILITY

Being careful to ensure that our evidence and research methods reach a standard above reproach does not prevent us from commenting on the great moral issues of our time, such as war, poverty, financial crises or inequality. In addressing these issues, sociologists are divided. Some centre their work on **professional recognition** and remain within academia, while others work with policy-makers. Others again feel the need to engage with the public and see that as a legitimate **extension** of their roles as sociologists. Burawoy (2005) avers that although there are some **overlaps** between these categories and some of us move between them, we now, in effect, **practise** four kinds of sociology – professional, critical, policy and public (Table 1.1).

TABLE 1.1 Burawoy's four types of sociology

Type of sociology	Common cognitive practices	Target audience
Professional sociology	Advanced theoretical and empirical work, using explicit scientific norms	Peers, those who read professional journals
Critical sociology	Foundational and normative, driven by moral vision	Critical intellectuals, those who engage in internal debates about sociology
Policy sociology	Empirical, concrete, applied and pragmatic	Policy-makers in government, business and the media
Public sociology	More accessible/relevant theoretical and empirical work, lectures and media appearances	Designated publics including students, the local community and religious groups

Source: Adapted from Burawoy (2005).

SOME MILESTONES IN THE HISTORY OF SOCIOLOGY

THE FRENCH REVOLUTION

A series of social upheavals that began in 1789 with peasant revolt, monarchical collapse and moderate middle-class leadership. From 1793 to 1795, the urban poor of Paris and other cities, led by radicals such as Robespierre, pushed the revolution in a more violent and nationalist direction. An increasing involvement in European wars also led to the successful mass mobilization of citizen armies and the centralization of power.

As we have mentioned, the discipline of sociology is much older than many of its students believe. It has its roots in the period after the French Revolution when political conflict, rapid urbanization and social turmoil convulsed European societies.

Intellectuals sought to explain both the bewildering chaos and the new possibilities around them. Karl Marx, for example, saw the French Revolution and the European revolutions of 1830 and 1848 as harbingers of a new revolutionary order that a class-conscious and politically motivated working class (he called workers the 'proletariat' after the dispossessed class of ancient Rome) would usher in. Box 1.1 is a summary of some of the most important developments in sociological thought from the mid-nineteenth century to the present day. It indicates how involvement in the discipline spread beyond the first industrial societies.

BOX 1.1 Timeline in sociology

- 1842** The publication of *Positive Philosophy* (1853) by **Auguste Comte** (1798–1857). Comte wanted to find regularities, even laws, in social life that resembled Newtonian physics. He allied sociology to the scientific models of the Enlightenment. His ideas were linked to those of scholars in the other two major social sciences – economics and political science. They dismissed philosophy as too speculative, theology as the rationalization of superstition, and history as too subjective and superficial. These